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Communicating Digital Humanities Work in Academic Libraries:

A Multi-Institution Rhetorical Analysis

Abstract

This study investigates how academic libraries in various US areas rhetorically create and convey their digital humanities work through external resources (including but not limited to their mission statements, institutional websites, and LibGuides). Although DH has experienced significant growth as an area for institutional investment, collaboration, and strategic positioning, there has been very little empirical research that has looked at how libraries communicate these roles to external audiences and how this communication affects perceptions of expertise, legitimacy, and collaboration potential. Through a qualitative content analysis of nine institutions: Stanford University, University of Washington, University of Virginia, Emory University, University of Illinois-Chicago, Northwestern University, University of Pittsburgh, Barnard College, and University of Nebraska-Lincoln, this study identifies patterns in terminology, framing strategies, labor visibility, and regional variations in DH self-presentation. This will be supplemented in future research by semi-structured interviews with librarians or DH staff, and the project will look at how communication choices influence faculty expectations, collaborative relationships, and perceived positioning of libraries within DH ecosystems. It is hypothesized that institutions with more mature DH infrastructures will use clearer, more

confident language about expertise and services. However, I hypothesize that more ambitious or unclear terminology will be used in younger programs. The research's conclusions can guide best practices for libraries looking to improve their institutional alignment, lessen misunderstandings in collaboration, and better clearly communicate the DH work they do.

Statement of the Research Problem

Consider a researcher looking for assistance with digital humanities (DH) work on the website of a university library. But all they come across are out-of-date project pages, ambiguous descriptions, and inadequate service explanations. This current state of uncertainty is a reflection of a broader problem in academic librarianship: the disparity between the amount of DH work that takes place in libraries and the public communication of this work. Academic libraries are becoming more and more important in fields including data curation, digital pedagogy, metadata consultancy, project creation, and digital preservation as DH scholarship spreads throughout higher education. Still, some of the language libraries use to describe such roles is ambiguous or inconsistent. It has become important to consider how these narratives are generated since public-facing communication shapes how academics, students, and outside partners contemplate libraries.

While this topic is part of a broader field of academic librarianship and digital scholarship. It does, however, concentrate on the language and communication techniques libraries employ to explain their DH engagement. Publicly accessible publications that serve as both institutional narratives and informational tools include websites, LibGuides, and mission statements. They communicate a library's values, its awareness of its DH identity, and its position within the larger academic community. Because communication directly impacts visibility, legitimacy, and collaboration potential, it is important to comprehend these narratives. For instance, Posner

(2013) contends that partners' perceptions of libraries as reliable participants in digital research are influenced by their power to express their DH capacity. Likewise, Warwick et al. (2008) found that many DH scholars remain unaware of what libraries offer. This suggests a communication gap that can hinder further interdisciplinary collaboration.

And while, it is accurate to say that DH in academic libraries is thriving right now, there is still an unevenness in recognition. Numerous organizations have formalized DH services, created digital scholarship centers, and employed specialist personnel (Millson-Martula & Gunn, 2019). Research continuously finds misunderstanding over DH labor and responsibilities despite these advancements. Critical DH work, particularly that of graduate students and staff, is often invisible in institutional narratives, as Opel and Simeone (2019) point out. Additionally, Brandenburg et al. (2017) show that faculty members' opinions of librarians in multidisciplinary research have a direct impact on the extent of their involvement (which directly highlights the significance of roles and responsibilities that are clearly stated.) When put together, a constant gap emerges. While the amount of DH work librarians are doing is increasing, their work still lacks rhetorical framing within public-facing materials.

As universities increase their investments in digital scholarship infrastructure, tools, and multidisciplinary research projects, this gap is especially relevant today. Libraries bear the danger of misrepresenting their competence in DH, undervaluing their efforts, or inadvertently disseminating false information. However, these are all possibilities that could happen when they do not strategically nor accurately communicate the work that they do in DH. As well, for many students and prospective partners/collaborators, the publicly accessible materials serve as their main point of contact. Therefore, the chances for meaningful involvement or resource support may be limited due to the often ambiguous and inadequate communications provided by

academic libraries. By further examining these communication strategies, a light can be shed on how libraries convey expertise, the institutional positioning of DH labor, and potential visibility gaps.

This research project aims to analyze how academic libraries across diverse regions and institutional types (more specifically, Stanford University; University of Washington, Seattle; University of Virginia; Emory University; University of Illinois - Chicago; Northwestern University; University of Pittsburgh; Barnard College; and University of Nebraska) present their DH identity through outward-facing materials. This study's primary research questions are: How do university libraries rhetorically create their digital humanities identities in communications with the public? What does this tell us about how institutions view work, knowledge, and cooperation? The research project hopes to find trends in emphasis, phrasing, and rhetorical framing through qualitative analysis of websites, LibGuides, and mission statements of these institutions. By concentrating on the communication strategies that influence how DH infrastructure and services are seen by others rather than the infrastructure or services themselves, it intends to fill a vacuum in the body of previous research.

The conclusions of this study might be of value to librarians, DH practitioners, administrators, and educational scholars. By understanding fundamental communication techniques will help the practitioner in crafting DH messaging that is more effective and clear, and by understanding rhetorical framing can help administrators understand why some types of labor are still underappreciated (or in some cases, even ignored). But overall, having a better grasp of how libraries characterize their contributions to digital scholarship should be helpful to DH academics. In the end, enhancing institutional communication can improve cooperation, make expectations clear, and encourage more precise identification of library expertise.

The rapid growth of DH activity within academic libraries has created an urgent need to understand the ways in which this work is publicly represented. This paper brings together research on digital librarianship, institutional rhetoric, and the politics of academic labor by examining the ways in which institutions describe their DH roles. What follows is a description of the research design, population and sampling strategy, the methods for collecting data, and the ethical considerations that form the basis of this project, informing the analysis of how communication constructs the DH landscape within academic libraries.

Purpose Statement

In order to find trends, inconsistencies, and opportunities for development, the purpose of this study is to comprehend how academic libraries from various U.S. regions portray and contextualize their work with DH in public-facing materials. The goal of this study is to provide practical insights into how perceptions of library work, competence, and collaborative potential are shaped by communication. This project is significant because, although a persistent but undocumented challenge exists, it examines the mismatch between what libraries do in DH and what they say they do publicly. This study offers data that supports improved communication tactics, greater campus alliances, and more equal visibility of digital labor by illuminating how institutions create DH narratives through language, labor framing, service descriptions, or organizational identification.

To put it briefly, this study aims to showcase how deliberate, transparent communication can enhance DH cooperation, fortify institutional coherence, and assist librarians in making sure that library contributions are appreciated and comprehended. In funding this project, stakeholders are

supporting research that furthers practical and scholarly understandings about DH infrastructure and organizational communication.

Literature Review

Key Terms

Digital Humanities (DH).

Digital humanities is a field of study that combines digital technologies, techniques, and infrastructures with humanities topics. According to Millson-Martula & Gunn (2019) and Warwick et al. (2008), it can involve everything from creating interactive visualizations to doing text-mining analysis or creating digital displays. Because DH looks different on every campus, people often describe it as more of a “community of practice” than a strict discipline. Collaboration and experimentation are usually at the center of it.

Digital Scholarship.

Digital scholarship overlaps with DH, but it casts a wider net. While DH focuses on humanities contexts, digital scholarship refers to digitally supported research across all disciplines, including STEM and social sciences (Vinopal & McCormick, 2013). In libraries, this often includes project support, digital publishing, data help, tool training, and consultations.

Librarian Roles in DH.

According to Brandenburg et al. (2017) and Posner (2013), librarians do a variety of tasks in DH work, including providing technical assistance, assisting with project management, and working as co-investigators or grant collaborators. Staffing levels, institutional culture, and how the library conveys its capabilities all influence how these roles seem. Numerous research

(Brandenburg et al., 2017; Kasten-Mutkus, 2019) have shown that unclear messaging can lead to misunderstandings about the level of cooperation or expertise of librarians.

Collaboration.

Academics, librarians, technicians, students, and sometimes outside partners work together in an iterative, hands-on fashion in DH. Establishing these common expectations early on is typically necessary for successful collaboration. Especially with regards to communication, project goals, and labor division (Brandenburg et al., 2017; Posner, 2013). According to earlier research, educators may not consider using libraries' DH services at the start of a project if they are not made explicit (Warwick et al., 2008).

Rhetorical Framing.

The way libraries publicly explain and position their DH work is known as rhetorical framing. (They often do this through websites, service models, mission statements, or even the language used in employment titles.) According to Posner (2013) and Kasten-Mutkus (2019), this framing influences how other students on campus see the library's function as a collaborator, consultant, service provider, or something else entirely. Because DH work often blurs boundaries between academic units, the way libraries talk about their role directly influences visibility and credibility.

Data Management.

Data management is about the behind-the-scenes activities such as organizing, classifying, storing, transferring, and preserving research data. DH may include large text datasets, multimedia files, metadata selections, and long-term preservation techniques. Faculty expectations vary a lot by discipline, which is one reason communication between researchers and libraries is so important (Akers & Doty, 2013).

Sustainability.

According to Vinopal and McCormick (2013), sustainability refers to the resources (i.e. the staffing, funding, infrastructure, and institutional planning) necessary to maintain a digital project or service over time. Since libraries are typically in a better position than individual departments to preserve long-term digital resources, sustainability is frequently one of the best justifications for getting involved in DH activity.

Visibility.

Visibility describes how aware researchers and campus partners are of a library's DH services, expertise, and ongoing projects. Several studies show that when DH academics have limited visibility. This is often the result of unclear or inconsistent communication, and as such digital humanists are less likely to approach the library as a collaborator (Warwick et al., 2008; Kasten-Mutkus, 2019). As a result, raising awareness is both strategic and promotional; assisting in meeting expectations and fostering collaborative relationships.

Introduction

Over the past 20 years, there have been several significant changes to the interaction between academic libraries and DH studies. As DH work has expanded, libraries have positioned themselves as collaborators in research, education, data curation, and the creation of digital projects. They have also positioned themselves as partners, service providers, facilitators, and sometimes full-time collaborators. This growth has brought identity, institutional stance, and labor to the forefront, raising questions about how libraries both identify and frame their functions internally and externally. Websites, LibGuides, and DH initiative pages are examples of some of the public-facing resources that have a significant impact on how educators, students, administrators, and outside partners view the purpose, capacity, and competency of library-based DH projects. The functional duties, professional competencies, and organizational problems of

librarians have all been clarified by study, but the discursive communication of these roles has received very little attention.

This literature review explores prior work on the intersections of librarianship, DH, collaboration, and institutional presentation as they relate to the definition, understanding, and representation of library roles. The review considers empirical and theoretical contributions to establish what is currently known about libraries' engagements in DH and identifies the gaps relative to rhetorical framing and public communication. Key concepts guiding this review include DH, collaboration, digital scholarship services, librarian labor, and institutional rhetoric, each of which appears in the literature with varying theoretical and practical emphasis. DH generally refers to computational, data-driven, or digitally mediated approaches to humanistic inquiry (Posner, 2013). Collaboration, in this context, encompasses relationships between librarians and scholars ranging from transactional support to sustained co-research partnerships (Brandenburg et al., 2017). Institutional rhetoric refers to the discursive strategies through which organizations construct narratives about their identity, mission, and expertise (Kasten-Mutkus, 2019).

The review is organized thematically. First, the review surveys foundational scholarship on libraries' engagement with DH. Second, it synthesizes literature addressing collaboration, labor, and organizational positioning. Third, it explores research highlighting communication gaps, visibility challenges, and issues of professional identity. Fourth, it examines literature on service design, scalability, and sustainability as these factors relate to rhetorical presentation. This review concludes with the identification of a significant gap in this research, namely a lack of systematic analysis of the rhetorical framing of DH-related library services in public-facing institutional documents. This gap supports the justification for the proposed study, which

explores the ways libraries have constructed narratives of DH engagement through their web-based communications.

Conceptual Foundations and Institutional Positioning

One of the first and most thorough analyses of academic libraries' function in the DH may be found in the edited collection by Millson-Martula and Gunn (2019). A comprehensive picture of how DH entered library discourse is provided by the collection's theoretical discussions, educational interventions, case studies, and institutional narratives. Tensions between traditional librarianship and DH, which is an expanding interdisciplinary discipline that frequently challenges conventional workflows, job descriptions, and organizational structures, are noted by contributors. The editors claim that libraries have assumed DH obligations in such a variety of ways that they frequently get dispersed across various instructional programs, special collections units, metadata teams, digital scholarship centers, and technological support roles.

The volume's breadth, which includes first-person stories of DH implementation from practitioners, administrators, and academics, is one of its methodological strengths. However, because some chapters are mainly descriptive while others critically deal with institutional politics and professional identity, this breadth results in some unevenness in terms of analytical rigor. The text is a fundamental source for comprehending how librarians understood their relationship to DH during a formative age, notwithstanding this division. According to Millson-Martula and Gunn (2019), libraries frequently occupy ambiguous roles in DH ecosystems. They are often expected to simultaneously offer project management, instructional support, and technical expertise while their approach leaves open problems regarding institutional rhetoric and public-facing identity development. This is because they pay less attention to how these expectations are articulated publicly.

Sula's (2013) conceptual model remains one of the field's clearest attempts to map how libraries position themselves within DH ecosystems. His framework parses library involvement into several key functional domains like curatorial work, technological infrastructure, and research assistance while emphasizing that none of these exist in isolation. Instead, they intersect through organizational decisions and service models that determine how DH support is structured. Crucially for this study, Sula argues that the way libraries describe these functions in policy documents, service statements, and other public materials directly shapes how visible and legitimate their DH roles appear to campus partners. This means outward-facing communication is not merely descriptive; it is constitutive of how DH work is understood and valued. Sula's model, therefore, provides a theoretical backbone for analyzing websites and LibGuides as rhetorical artifacts. It supports the premise that institutional language affects not only faculty awareness but also the perceived credibility of libraries as DH collaborators; a central issue underlying this research project.

Early Studies of DH User Needs and Library Visibility

Warwick et al. (2008) carried out one of the first significant empirical investigations examining the information consumption and library usage of DH scholars. The authors found that many digital humanists were unaware of the services that librarians could offer or considered library involvement to be 'incidental' to their research, using both survey methodologies and interviews. According to their findings, the underappreciation of librarian expertise was caused by libraries' inability to properly convey their value. Despite the fact that the study was conducted before digital scholarship centers were widely established, its findings are still important: libraries' work is invisible when their DH duties are not clearly stated.

The methodology of Warwick et al. (2008) offers baseline insights into how awareness gaps are developed and has the advantage of gathering DH perceptions early in the field's growth. The study highlights a persistent issue. There is a discrepancy between what libraries offer and what patrons perceive them to offer. The communication deficiencies are deduced from user views, but it does not directly analyze institutional communication methods. This emphasizes the necessity for current studies that look into how libraries create and spread DH-related messaging through their materials that are accessible to the public.

Librarians' Involvement in Interdisciplinary Scholarship

The participation of librarians in interdepartmental grant-funded initiatives, including but not limited to DH projects, is discussed by Brandenburg et al. (2017). The authors investigate the types of roles librarians play, such as co-investigator, consultant, collaborator, and support staff, to the degree in which their colleagues in academia acknowledge their contributions using questionnaires and interviews. Their findings indicate that librarians frequently contribute significantly to research projects without receiving recognition as collaborators. Institutional, cultural, and rhetorical factors, such as how organizations portray library work and how librarians describe their own competence, have an impact on these interactions. Although it prioritizes internal experiences above external presentations, Brandenburg et al.'s (2017) study provides a strong empirical model of collaboration in terms of technique. However, this work is essential to defining the concept of collaboration itself. The authors argue that poor communication (whether interpersonal, institutional, or organizational) is the primary cause of misconceptions or undervaluation of librarians' work. This contributes to the present study by emphasizing that collaboration is a function of rhetorical positioning rather than labor division.

Current DH Practices and Librarians' Self-Perceptions

Habing's (2025) 2024 Digital Humanities in U.S. Academic Libraries case study collection provides a much-needed up-to-date overview of DH practices in various institutional settings. The book highlights five recurrent themes of DH activity based on semi-structured interviews: instructional programs, personnel structures, technology infrastructure, physical and virtual space, and faculty cooperation methods. These themes shed light on the physical realities of DH work and the internal logic that shapes librarians' discussions of their involvement with digital research. The case studies provide a deep understanding of how librarians themselves view their jobs. However, they pay less attention to the rhetorical constructions that are visible to the outside world, such as websites, guiding language, and public service descriptions. This distinction is crucial for the current study, which focuses on the communication of DH services to audiences outside of libraries. As such, the volume is useful for understanding the institutional context informing librarians' self-perceptions, but it also underscores the gap between internal narratives and the public representations examined in this research.

Identity, Legitimacy, and Rhetorical Positioning in DH Work

The cultural and identity-based challenges libraries face when entering DH areas are highlighted by Posner (2013). Drawing from her experience as a DH practitioner, she has argued that in order to overcome faculty skepticism about libraries, libraries must develop and articulate appealing narratives about their DH potential. Posner asserts that communications that are unclear or excessively modest damage librarians' credibility, whereas communications that are open and self-assured can promote cooperation and foster confidence. Her research emphasizes language as a useful tactic: if libraries want to be regarded as genuine DH partners, they must convey

competence, authority, and dedication. Posner's article is contemplative rather than empirical, but it has an impact here because of how clearly it articulates identity politics in DH. According to Posner (2013), misconceptions arise not only from structural issues but also from the narratives libraries tell (or fail to tell) about themselves. Posner defines communication as a crucial aspect of institutional posture. The article's focus on rhetorical clarity, legitimacy, and perception clearly supports the fundamental justification for studying public-facing communication.

Competencies, Skills, and the Construction of Professional Value

By combining requirements from job descriptions, interviews, and professional guidelines, King (2018) investigates the competences anticipated of digital scholarship librarians. According to her findings, librarians involved in DH possess a wide range of skills, including data curation, project management, teaching, programming, and communication. The aspirational narratives that organizations construct about DH librarianship are another reason why King's work is significant. Job advertisements create romanticized notions of what DH librarians ought to be in addition to describing jobs. King's 2018 study advances knowledge of how organizations express value and expertise. Her findings show that institutions heavily rely on rhetorical constructs such as "collaborative," "innovative," or "hybrid" labor to define professional identity, even while they are not specifically focused on rhetorical framing of public-facing papers. This implies that, even prior to the hiring of librarians, institutional discourse has a crucial influence in determining the scope and perception of DH activity.

Communication as a Determinant of Library Engagement in DH

Akers and Doty (2013) discuss disciplinary differences in faculty expectations around research data management, showing how scholars' interactions with library services are dependent on

their perception of librarians' expertise. Their study, though not DH-specific, provides a compelling account of the place of communication in framing researcher behavior. Faculty who view librarians as having important knowledge will ask for assistance, while those who do not will stay away from libraries completely. This is consistent with the broader argument that rhetorical framing influences how libraries are viewed as peripheral players, partners, or service providers. Combining their surveys with qualitative analysis, their methodology yields sound results about disciplinary norms and librarian-faculty interactions. The study is relevant in pointing out that the use and collaboration patterns are shaped by communication practices and by the narratives through which libraries present their expertise. In its application to DH, this reinforces the need to understand how libraries articulate their DH capacities publicly.

Visibility and Public-Facing Representation in DH

Kasten-Mutkus (2019) places the key to understanding DH identity and institutional roles in public communication. While her text does not deal exclusively with libraries, her argument that DH's legitimacy and visibility rely on how organizations describe their work through online platforms, social media, and institutional documents suggests that for libraries, public-facing rhetoric directly impacts perceptions of expertise, labor, and collaboration potential. Kasten-Mutkus' work represents one of the few sources that explicitly connect DH practice with questions of visibility and communicative framing, making it central to the rationale of the present study.

Burns (2016) furthers this line of inquiry in an Irish case study that investigated how librarians communicate DH work. Burns interviewed librarians and analyzed documents to discover that most librarians feel responsible for advocating for DH internally and externally but that few have

access to robust institutional messaging frameworks. Her findings indicate that while librarians are aware of the need for rhetorical positioning, organizational structures or communications policies often get in the way. Burns (2016) reminds us that the work of promotion and outreach is central to much DH librarianship, yet is understudied in the literature.

These two works, Kasten-Mutkus' from 2019 and Burns's from 2016, together offer the strongest evidence that public-facing communication is an understudied yet consequential dimension of DH librarianship. Both studies point toward a significant research gap regarding how libraries craft and present narratives of DH engagement to external audiences.

Invisible Labor and Institutional Narratives in DH

Opel and Simeone (2019) draw attention to a facet of DH work that is frequently disregarded in both public messaging and institutional planning. The mostly unseen labor that keeps DH labs running, relies particularly on the contributions of graduate students. The scope of the organizational, emotional, and intellectual labor that is left out of formal descriptions of DH infrastructures is revealed by their examination. Instead, institutional narratives tend to flatten or obscure these efforts, emphasizing outcomes rather than processes. This critique is deeply relevant for a study focused on rhetorical framing, because project websites and lab descriptions often participate in the very erasure Opel and Simeone describe. The authors highlight the politics of representation present in descriptions of DH work that appear impartial by demonstrating how invisible labor is normalized through institutional communication. Their argument reinforces the justification for examining documents that are visible to the public: these texts actively influence views of expertise, legitimacy, and labor distribution within DH ecosystems rather than merely providing information.

Scalability, Administrative Decision-Making, and Strategic Narratives

Vinopal and McCormick (2013) consider the organizational challenges facing libraries working to develop DH services, highlighting resourcing, staffing models, and long-term sustainability. Their study is based on administrative case studies, informed by their practices at large research institutions. The authors maintain that sustainable DH support requires explicit prioritization, transparent service design, and alignment with the institution. Notably, they observe that communication underpins each of these processes: the administrators must clearly articulate the scope, limits, and goals of the DH services to avoid misaligned expectations.

Vinopal and McCormick's emphasis on strategic decision-making points out another dimension of rhetorical framing: how constraints are communicated by libraries. Their results show that it is in the institutional narratives about staffing levels, expertise, and service availability where influence over how stakeholders engage with DH resources lies. When a library rhetorically positions itself as capable of fully supporting any DH initiative, it risks its own overextension. It runs the risk of being ignored when it places itself too narrowly. Rhetorical positioning thereby affects demand, workload, and institutional expectations.

Rhetorical Framing and Its Impact on DH Collaboration

Vandegrift and Varner (2013) explore how libraries and DH centers can establish mutually supportive, strategically aligned relationships, positioning communication as central to successful collaboration. They argue that rather than shared offerings, long-lasting partnerships are formed via open communication and shared principles. Some examples of how libraries convey their DH obligations and abilities include the language used to describe services, the rhetorical style of mission statements, and the tone of outreach materials. They contend that these factors have a big impact on whether libraries are seen as supplementary service units or equal partners. This attention to communicative positioning aligns directly with the present study's focus on public-facing texts. In illustrating how institutional self-representation shapes external perceptions of legitimacy and expertise, Vandegrift and Varner reinforce the notion that websites, LibGuides, and other outward-facing materials play an active role in defining the library's place within the DH landscape. Their work thus provides a strong conceptual grounding for examining the rhetorical strategies taken up across institutions in this

The Intersection of Digital Libraries, Metadata, and DH Work

Zhang et al. (2015) explore the intersection between digital libraries and DH infrastructures. They explored how librarians manage their responsibilities in digitization, project management, digital preservation, and metadata. The authors also point out that libraries often act as a link between the humanistic and technological spheres, bridging the gap between research demands and digital systems. Librarians must mediate between technological limitations and academic objectives, which frequently requires a lot of communication work. Furthermore, the libraries' perceptions inside DH ecosystems are influenced by their capacity to express their technical responsibilities. Scholars may miss libraries' potential contributions to study design, data interpretation, or methodological advancement if libraries present themselves only as service providers. On the other hand, libraries' centrality in DH can be shaped by highlighting their contribution to the development and maintenance of digital infrastructures. Because it shows how institutional narrative influences scholarly involvement, our analysis thus directly supports a demand for research on public-facing communication.

Gaps in the Literature

Throughout the sources under review, there are several recurrent themes: the complexity of the DH roles of librarians; collaboration; institutional positioning; and communication. The functional, administrative, and organizational aspects of DH librarianship are well-documented in research. The perception by faculty, identity struggles, sustainability concerns, and need for better internal communication are also touched on in literature. However, one important issue that has not gotten enough attention is the rhetorical framing of library DH perspectives in publications that are accessible to the public.

Although they discuss communication issues and knowledge gaps, Warwick et al. (2008) and Akers and Doty (2013) do little to examine institutional papers. However, although their assessments remain limited by particular case studies or general discussions on visibility, Burns (2016) and Kasten-Mutkus (2019) come the closest to assessing public-facing communication. A multi-institution study has not looked closely at how libraries describe their DH services, expertise, and possibilities for collaboration on their websites, LibGuides, or digital scholarship pages. This omission speaks volumes about how crucial web-based communication is to contemporary academic engagement.

Another gap concerns the relationship between rhetorical framing and collaboration. Though Brandenburg et al. (2017) and Posner (2013) both indicated that communication shapes collaborative dynamics, neither has analyzed how external representations shape perceptions or expectations at the outset. Understanding how libraries represent themselves to potential DH partners is crucial given the epistemological debates occurring around issues of visibility, recognition, and legitimacy.

This study differs from prior DH scholarship by focusing on how libraries communicate their digital scholarship and DH work, rather than on the development of DH infrastructure, staffing models, or laboratory spaces. It directly addresses these gaps through a comparative, multi-institutional analysis of public-facing DH library web pages that examine how institutional rhetoric constructs narratives of expertise, collaboration, and identity.

Increased Investment in DH and the Need to Study Communication Strategies

Over the last two decades, colleges and universities have significantly expanded their investment in digital scholarship and DH to support emerging methods of research and to signal innovation

at the institutional level. Libraries have become central to this growth. This is seen in the establishment of digital scholarship labs within libraries, hiring specialized librarians, and developing collaborative infrastructures that support computational, multimodal, and data-driven research (Maron, 2015). This trend is also national in scope. Surveys of library administrators demonstrate a spike in DH centers after the year 2005, while numerous case studies from the 2010s chronicle expanded staffing and significant physical space (Library of Congress, 2020). National funding patterns further reinforce this momentum. For example, the National Endowment for the Humanities awarded many DH projects in 2023. Large-scale digitization, preservation projects, and the use of virtual reality teaching resources in coursework are some of the projects that took place in collaboration with academic libraries or DH centers. (NEH, 2023). A growing need for libraries to strategically promote their DH work is supported by these trends. Understanding how libraries frame these activities (and how these decisions either reflect or obscure the realities of digital scholarly labor) becomes crucial. DH initiatives, as the studies show, increasingly determine institutional identity and signal competitiveness in research.

Conclusion

There are numerous and several various types of library assistance, facilitation, and collaboration in DH studies documented within the literature on DH and academic libraries. The early development of DH in libraries can be read in foundational texts that emphasize its organizational complexity and changing responsibilities. Librarians' contributions are underestimated or misinterpreted due to both some structural dynamics and rhetorical positioning, according to research on collaboration and professional identity. Research on visibility and communication concerns also reveals that public-facing representations have a significant impact on how library labor and expertise are regarded. The importance of rhetorical

clarity in establishing expectations and influencing institutional involvement is emphasized by analyses of service design and sustainability.

Despite these efforts, there is still a significant knowledge gap regarding how libraries use institutional papers that are visible to the public to portray their DH activities to external audiences. Although current study acknowledges these communication difficulties, it does not thoroughly examine the rhetorical tools that libraries employ to create their own DH identities. This chapter will demonstrate how libraries negotiate visibility, legitimacy, and collaboration potential within DH ecosystems in order to close this gap.

By examining the rhetorical framing of DH services in library websites across various academic institutions, the proposed study would close this gap. This study will demonstrate how libraries create identities, express labor, and place themselves within the larger DH landscape by analyzing and comparing institutional narratives. This contribution will extend the literature by linking discourse, identity, and collaboration in ways not fully explored in existing scholarship.

Methodology

Research Design

This qualitative multiple-case study investigates how academic libraries communicate their DH work through institutional websites, LibGuides, public documentation, and related online materials. The multiple-case structure allows for systematic comparison across institutions that vary by region, institutional type, research intensity, and level of DH infrastructure. A case study approach is best for the research questions because they center on rhetorical construction,

meaning-making, and identity formation; phenomena better understood through contextual, interpretive analysis rather than statistical generalization. This design blends directed content analysis (Hsieh & Shannon, 2005), discourse analysis, and cross-case thematic synthesis (Stake, 2006; Yin, 2018). When available, interviews with two to three DH librarians per institution improve triangulation and further ensure that rhetorical findings from online resources are contextualized with internal viewpoints. This interpretive methodological framework is consistent with research on collaborative identity development, DH labor, and communication (e.g., Posner, 2013; Opel & Simeone, 2019).

Population and Sampling Method

The target population consists of U.S. academic libraries with an active DH presence. For this study, a DH presence is defined as meeting all three inclusion criteria:

1. Active DH or digital scholarship–related web presence, such as a LibGuide, DH landing page, or lab website;
2. Evidence of librarian or library-staff engagement in DH activities, such as project participation, consultations, instruction, or lab operation;
3. Publicly accessible online materials (websites, policy documents, project descriptions, staff profiles, etc.).

Because this study needs examples that are rich in information and have adequate rhetorical data, a purposeful sampling technique is employed. The sample intentionally captures institutional diversity across five major U.S. regions (Northeast, South, Midwest, West, and Plains), across

public and private classifications, and across different Carnegie research designations (R1 vs. non-R1). In addition to addressing regional DH heterogeneity and preventing an overrepresentation of coastal or privileging highly resourced institutions, this variety improves transferability.

The final sample includes nine institutions with Stanford University and the University of Washington–Seattle representing the **West**; the University of Virginia and Emory University representing the **South**; the University of Illinois–Chicago and Northwestern University representing the **Midwest**; the University of Pittsburgh and Barnard College representing the **Northeast**; and the University of Nebraska–Lincoln representing the **Plains** region. For qualitative multi-site analysis, a sample of nine cases is suitable since it allows for both significant diversity across instances and depth within cases. A statistical power analysis is not necessary because the study is qualitative and exploratory. Instead, topic saturation, the point at which additional instances no longer yield significantly new rhetorical patterns, is used to determine sufficient.

Case Selection Rationale

Stanford University, the University of Washington, the University of Virginia, Emory University, the University of Illinois–Chicago, Northwestern University, the University of Pittsburgh, Barnard College, and the University of Nebraska–Lincoln are among the nine universities that were chosen to be case studies for this research. They were chosen to offer a purposefully diverse and informative collection of instances. When taken as a whole, they show a broad range of institutional kinds, geographic variety, and the maturity of DH infrastructure. With internationally renowned DH centers and strong traditions of digital research production,

Stanford, the University of Virginia, and the University of Nebraska–Lincoln are all longstanding leaders in the field of digital humanities. In a similar vein, mature models with distinct organizational structures are offered by Northwestern University and the University of Washington. They also have substantial digital scholarship services embedded within their library systems rather than services positioned as standalone DH centers. Additionally, organizations with rapidly evolving DH ecosystems include Emory and the University of Pittsburgh. Over the past ten years, both have made substantial expenditures in digital scholarship laboratories, digital archives, and interdisciplinary projects. This in direct contrast to Barnard College and the University of Illinois–Chicago. Both of which offer examples of establishments with relatively small, decentralized, and developing DH programs. This allows one to consider the rhetorical framing in contexts where DH work exists, yet remains inchoate as an institutional presence. With this, the spread across public and private institutions, R1 and non-R1 environments, and diverse regional contexts strengthens the analytic value of the cross-case synthesis and ensures that the study can compare rhetorical strategies across both highly resourced and developing DH ecosystems.

Human Subjects Review and Ethical Considerations

Because this project includes both analysis of publicly available documents and optional interviews with professional staff, it will be submitted to the University at Albany Institutional Review Board (IRB) as a minimal-risk study.

Public-Facing Document Analysis

The primary dataset, such as library DH webpages, LibGuides, and digital scholarship documentation consists of publicly accessible materials. As such, analysis of these documents does not constitute human subjects research on its own. However, some ethical considerations do still apply. The examination of institutional rhetoric entails professional sensitivities, since one's interpretation of language might indirectly reflect on the work of specific librarians, DH staff, or administrators. In this respect, ethical considerations include not only issues of standard confidentiality but protection against potential harm to professional reputation and workplace relations. To mitigate these risks, all interviewees will be provided with pseudonyms unless explicit written consent is given to publish their actual names. Findings will be presented such that all critical observations of rhetorical strategy and institutional positioning will be framed at the organizational level, avoiding personal attribution or evaluative statements about individual librarians.

All interview data will be stored on encrypted and password-protected devices and will be available only to the researcher. Any participants will be informed that participation is voluntary, that they may withdraw at any time, and that participation or non-participation has no implications for professional standing. A full IRB application will be submitted prior to interviews; additionally, CITI certification is complete. Given the nature of this project, where public content is analyzed and minimal-risk interview data are collected, the study qualifies for a minimal risk designation; however, the added measure of identification and mitigation of potential reputational repercussions constitutes responsible management of professional discourse across academic library contexts.

Interviews with DH Librarians or Staff

Interviews will proceed only after receiving IRB approval. Ethical protocols include:

- **Informed Consent:** Participants will receive detailed information about the study's goals, their rights, and the voluntary nature of participation.
- **Right to Withdraw:** Participants may discontinue at any time without penalty.
- **Confidentiality:**
 - Pseudonyms will be used unless explicit permission for attribution is granted.
 - Institutional names may remain identifiable because institutions themselves are the unit of analysis; however, individuals will not be directly attributed to sensitive statements.
- **Data Security:** All digital data will be stored on encrypted, access-controlled OneDrive folders.
- **Researcher Training:** I have also completed CITI Responsible Conduct of Research training.

Risk Assessment

The study poses minimal risk. The primary potential sensitivity relates to the professional implications of discussing institutional communication practices. To mitigate this, interview questions are designed to avoid evaluative framing and instead focus on descriptive and experiential accounts.

Variables and Measurements

Variable Identification

This study examines how academic libraries communicate and construct their roles within the DH landscape. Although the overall design is qualitative, several conceptual variables guide the analysis of rhetorical framing across cases. These variables, which will be both conceptual and operational, will be able to reflect patterns observed in online communication and interview data.

The independent variables in this study include institutional type and the presence of DH infrastructure. Institutional type will refer to whether a library is part of a public or private institution and whether it has a Carnegie R1 or non-R1 classification. This distinction may influence how DH activities are described and the degree of rhetorical emphasis on collaboration. Library DH infrastructure denotes the existence and extent of DH facilities, staff, or programs (e.g., a DH center, digital scholarship librarian, or active DH projects). These factors are expected to affect how a library frames its expertise and engagement in DH.

The dependent variables are centered on the rhetorical framing of librarian roles and tone of communication. Rhetorical framing refers to how librarians are represented in DH contexts, such as collaborators, service providers, facilitators, or consultants in public-facing materials. Tone of communication refers to the expressive stance used in describing these roles, ranging from institutional and formal to collegial, promotional, or advisory. These outcomes will be derived from textual coding of LibGuides, DH websites, and related institutional materials.

A number of control variables will also be taken into account in this study, including geographic region and institutional size. Both the student population or full-time equivalent (FTE) library staff data will be used to determine the size of the institution, and the U.S. Census regional

categories (Northeast, South, Midwest, and West) will be used to determine the region. These safeguards make sure that variations in rhetorical framing aren't exclusively caused by regional or resource-related reasons.

Two additional variables function as mediating or moderating factors. Perceived expertise or authority serves as a mediating variable, representing the degree to which libraries project confidence or authority in DH through terms like “leaders,” “partners,” or “supporters.” As a moderating variable, librarian self-perception will be derived from the semi-structured interviews that will be conducted to examine how librarians characterize their DH duties in relation to the public discourse of their institution. When combined, these factors will make it easier to compare how one feels about oneself inside and how one communicates with others.

Variable Clarification

Although this study does not use statistical hypothesis testing, the independent, dependent, mediating, and moderating variables provide conceptual guides that frame the qualitative analysis rather than quantifiable units to be measured numerically. Institutional type and presence of DH infrastructure-what were determined to be the independent variables-serve as contextual anchors to help make sense of the rhetorical environment in which libraries construct their digital humanities identities. The dependent variables, rhetorical framing and tone of communication, are the main phenomena to be investigated through qualitative content analysis. They act as lenses for seeing how various roles, expertise, and collaborative positioning within DH are conveyed in public-facing materials.

The relationship between structural capacity (e.g., DH personnel, centers) and public representation may be strengthened or weakened by institutional discourse. This is demonstrated

by perceived expertise, a conceptual mediating variable. Similarly, by capturing how librarians' internal conceptions of their DH identity impact (or deviate from) the external rhetorical narrative, the moderating variable (such as librarian self-perception) explains variation between situations. The study, which is situated within a qualitative, interpretive framework, gives contextual complexity, meaning, and representation precedence over measurement or prediction. They serve to direct targeted investigation, facilitate cross-case comparison, and organize the interpretive reasoning that links institutional traits to rhetorical results.

Operationalization

Each variable will be operationalized through qualitative coding and metadata documentation. The institutional type will be recorded using the Carnegie Classification data or from official institutional websites, coded categorically as public/private and R1/non-R1. Library DH infrastructure will be identified through the presence of DH resources and coded on an ordinal scale (0 = none, 1 = limited [LibGuide only], 2 = moderate [consultation/program], 3 = extensive [dedicated lab or center]).

Rhetorical framing will be coded through directed content analysis (Hsieh & Shannon, 2005) of textual materials. Each library's DH-related web content will be reviewed for language positioning librarians as collaborators, service providers, consultants, or facilitators. The preliminary coding scheme will be adapted from prior scholarship on DH collaboration and rhetorical framing (Posner, 2013). The tone of communication will be analyzed using NVivo's word frequency and sentiment features, coded as 1 = institutional, 2 = collegial, 3 = promotional, or 4 = advisory.

Perceived expertise or authority will be identified by counting instances and contexts of self-referential terms (e.g., “leader,” “expert,” “support,” “consult”). These will be coded on an ordinal scale from low (0–1 mentions) to high (3+ mentions with context). Librarian self-perception will be derived from thematic analysis of interview transcripts, using codes such as “collaborator,” “consultant,” or “facilitator.” These codes will be compared to corresponding public-facing materials to assess alignment or dissonance between institutional discourse and personal perception.

Control variables such as institutional size (ratio scale) and geographic region (nominal scale) will be used to contextualize findings rather than for statistical control. Data will be recorded in Excel and imported into NVivo for case comparison. No major transformations are expected, though some standardization of code frequencies (e.g., normalization by word count) may be performed for comparison across libraries.

Extra measures will be taken to boost the study's credibility during the coding and analysis phase. Reflexive memoing will be used to document the researcher's changing interpretations, positionality, and analytical decisions during data collection and coding. An audit trail that includes codebook changes, coding updates, and methodological decisions made during analysis will also be maintained to guarantee openness and reproducibility. In the event that interviews are held, participants will have the option to participate in member checking, which will enable them to improve or clarify their remarks prior to final interpretation. Inter-coder reliability will be assessed during the pilot coding phase; if a second coder participates, the study will aim for a

Cohen's kappa of approximately .70 or higher to demonstrate acceptable agreement before full coding proceeds.

Data Analysis Plan

After the variables have been conceptually established and operationalized for qualitative interpretation, it is necessary to describe how the data will be analyzed in a methodical and theoretically sound manner. The study's emphasis on meaning-making, rhetorical construction, and institutional identification necessitates that the analytical method take into account both interpretative flexibility and organized coding. Because of this, the analysis incorporates a number of qualitative techniques that collectively represent the ways in which positions in the digital humanities are expressed in various institutional contexts. The following section describes how directed content analysis, thematic analysis, and cross-case synthesis will interact to form a cohesive methodological framework capable of addressing the research questions.

Analysis Methods

The analytical strategy will employ qualitative multiple case study procedures and content analysis to examine how libraries communicate their DH roles. Directed content analysis (Hsieh & Shannon, 2005) supplies the deductive structure for the study, applying codes that have been informed by prior research on DH collaboration, librarian labor, and rhetorical positioning. This allows the researcher to use this method to systematically locate language patterns related to collaboration, expertise, identity, audience, and tone. As new concepts surface in the data, inductive refinement will expand the coding scheme, preserving interpretive flexibility.

To enhance analytic rigor, the study incorporates several trustworthiness strategies. Reflexive memoing will be used throughout the content and thematic analysis processes to capture analytic judgments and document how interpretations evolve. Transparency and methodological dependability will be further supported by an audit trail. It will include coding logs, codebook iterations, decision memos, and workflow notes. Intercoder reliability will be evaluated throughout the pilot coding phase to confirm the consistency and intelligibility of the coding scheme. If more than one coder is involved, the study will target a Cohen's kappa of .70 or above before proceeding with full-case coding.

DH LibGuides, library DH webpages, and other online resources from nine U.S. research universities will be closely examined and coded as part of the document analysis process. The tone, audience, and institutional voice will be examined, along with rhetorical patterns that place librarians in DH contexts as leaders, collaborators, or supporters. To find both similar and different rhetorical methods, a cross-case synthesis will then examine trends across institutions (Yin, 2018; Stake, 2006).

Thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006) will be applied to interview transcripts in order to capture librarians' self-perceptions of their DH roles, their interpretations of institutional discourse, and their experiences navigating DH expectations. These thematic codes will then be compared with the document-based codes in order to notice any alignment or dissonance between internal professional identity and external rhetorical messaging. The integration of these two analytic techniques strengthens the validity of the findings by grounding interpretations in both textual representation and lived professional experience. The thematic codes from the

interview data will be compared to document-based codes in order to explore congruence or dissonance between librarians' self-perceptions and institutional narratives. This combination of content and thematic analysis supports triangulation and enhances credibility through data source convergence (Patton, 2015).

The final stage of the data analysis plan for this research is a cross-case synthesis (Yin 2018), where the research seeks to identify patterns across institutions, including how rhetorical strategies vary by institutional type, region, and DH infrastructure. Synthesizing the themes across cases allows the study to look beyond description and interpret how broader institutional narratives shape the visibility, expertise, and collaborative positioning of librarians in digital humanities work. Taken together, these three methods form a triangulated analytic framework that captures both the rhetorical construction and lived reality of DH librarianship.

All of these analytical methods are well suited to the study's interpretive framework, which draws on both rhetorical and discourse theory. Because the research questions used center on meaning, representation, and identity construction rather than variable testing; the qualitative methods provide the necessary flexibility for contextual interpretation while maintaining systematic rigor (Saldaña, 2021).

Technical Implementation

In addition to organizing the institutional metadata and variable classifications using Microsoft Excel, I want to perform all coding and analysis in NVivo. NVivo is appropriate for this project,

in my opinion, because of its ability to manage large text datasets, support hierarchical coding structures, and facilitate cross-case comparisons. Additionally, I am also considering conducting a preliminary word frequency and collocation analysis using Voyant Tools in order to identify repeated rhetorical words. Right now, my methodical process plan is:

1. Compiling and archiving DH-related webpages and LibGuides for each selected library.
2. Developing an initial codebook based on literature-derived categories.
3. Conducting pilot coding on one case to refine code definitions.
4. Applying the final codebook to all cases in NVivo.
5. Performing within-case analysis to identify major themes.
6. Conducting cross-case synthesis to compare patterns across institutions.
7. Triangulating interview data (if available) with document findings.

The preliminary analyses will include exploratory word frequency analysis and a pilot round of coding to assess intercoder reliability and thematic coherence. Missing or incomplete data (e.g., limited online presence for certain institutions) will be transparently documented as a study limitation. Some expected outliers, like unusually robust or minimal DH programs, will be analyzed contextually rather than statistically excluded as they may also offer insight into rhetorical extremes.

As part of the technical workflow, intercoder reliability testing will be integrated into the pilot coding phase within NVivo. A subset of texts will be double-coded in order to evaluate the

codebook's consistency, and agreement statistics (such Cohen's kappa) will be generated. Any discrepancies will direct modifications to the code definitions prior to the full dataset being written. Reflexive memos and an organized audit trail will be kept in NVivo and auxiliary documentation files during this procedure. This guarantees openness in theme development, coding choices, and analytical interpretation.

Traditional assumptions of normality or homoscedasticity are not directly relevant in this study because it does not have any use of inferential statistics. When comparing code frequencies descriptively, data standardization (e.g., word count ratios) is required to provide uniform interpretive validity across the cases.

The ultimate goal of my analytical plan is to offer a more thorough comprehension of the evolving function of librarianship in the ecosystem of DH. In order to facilitate a comprehensive investigation of how libraries create and convey their identities in DH, I intend to accomplish this by incorporating rhetorical, institutional, and perceptual factors into my research.

Strengths and Limitations

This study's purposeful, multi-regional sampling technique is one of its main advantages. Nine universities from the West, South, Midwest, Northeast, and Plains were chosen for the study in order to cover a wide range of regional contexts. This breadth increases the transferability of findings across different types of academic environments. Another strength lies in the use of methodological triangulation. The study's credibility can be increased by the combination of semi-structured interviews and qualitative content analysis, which offer many viewpoints on the

rhetorical framing of DH work. This future hybrid method enhances the interpretive insights and enables cross-validation of the data.

The study also benefits from its focus on real, public-facing documents. Analyzing websites and LibGuides, artifacts that actively shape faculty and researcher perceptions, ensures strong ecological validity. These materials capture how DH work is presented in authentic institutional contexts rather than relying on internal or hypothetical representations. Additionally, the project is highly relevant and applicable to practice. The anticipated outcomes can directly influence institutional decision-making, shape future LibGuide design, enhance DH service messaging, and aid in the creation of policy texts. By drawing on theoretical frameworks pertaining to digital labor visibility, scholarly communication, and digital scholarship practices, the work is also firmly rooted in already established DH and library scholarship.

The study does also contain a number of shortcomings despite its numerous advantages. By specifically representing universities with well-established DH programs, purposeful sampling may introduce bias and can also hinder understanding of developing or underresourced areas. Consequently, more developed or better-supported DH environments may be overly reflected in the rhetorical patterns seen. Another limitation involves the dynamic nature of web content. Institutional websites and LibGuides change frequently, meaning the data collected represent a specific moment rather than a stable or enduring depiction of DH communication. This temporal instability may affect the consistency or longevity of the findings.

Additionally, there are substantial institutional differences in the visibility of DH labor, which creates some analytical difficulties. Some work related to digital scholarship is purposefully kept behind the scenes, especially when it comes to technical or infrastructure-related activities. Even when the work itself is significant, this invisibility makes it challenging to evaluate rhetorical presence in its whole.

Finally, for changes to the study in the future, data based on interviews may have bias and positionality problems. Librarians may describe their work in a defensive, strategic, or aspirational manner, depending on the institutional environment and professional requirements. Reflexivity is required to account for the interviewer's impact and the interpretive character of the responses. Because the study is qualitative, its findings are transferable but not generalizable to all U.S. institutions.

Budget Table

Category	Cost	Notes
Researcher Labor (around 120 hours at \$20/hr)	\$2400*	For data collection, coding, transcription, analysis
Transcription Software (Otter.ai 6 month subscription)	\$90*	For potential interview transcriptions
Recording Equipment (USB mic)	\$60*	Enhances clarity for interviews

Travel for Interviews (Local Transit)	\$120*	Metro/bus fare for campus visits
Qualitative Analysis Software (NVivo Student License)	\$120*	Coding and theme analysis
External Harddrive (1TB)	\$90	Secure local storage
Cloud Storage	\$20	Secure data storage
Printing/Materials	\$40*	Consent forms, notes
Research Incentives (9 participants with \$20 gift cards each)	\$180*	Encourages participation
Contingency (5%)	\$150	Buffer for unexpected costs
Total	\$3270*	

Budget Discussion

Due to the time-consuming nature of qualitative analysis, which includes coding and iterative theme development, it is expected that the researcher labor is the biggest expense. Particularly for busy DH employees, incentives can ensure interview participation. Reliability is increased and efficient, rigorous coding is supported by NVivo and transcribing tools. Flexibility for unforeseen requirements (such as additional interviews, printing, or software extensions) is

ensured by a tiny contingency. However, most of this is a tentative budget as interviewing may not happen as a part of the project. Thus the current anticipated fee is \$260, for an external hard drive, secure cloud storage, and a contingency fee in case an unexpected cost arises.

Hypothesized Findings

Based on the literature review, the study anticipates notable differences between institutions with long-established DH infrastructures and those still developing their programs. Universities such as Stanford, Northwestern, and the University of Virginia are expected to present clearer and more confident rhetorical framing of their DH services. Their web materials are likely to foreground expertise and consultation, articulate robust service models, highlight established partnerships, and feature the visibility of specialized staff. These institutions also tend to reference sustainability and long-term planning, reinforcing their maturity and stability in DH work. In contrast, institutions with emerging DH efforts, such as Barnard or the University of Illinois Chicago, may rely on more aspirational or generalized language. Their descriptions are expected to be more ambiguous, offering broad definitions of DH, less explicit discussions of labor, and less clearly articulated service structures.

Across all institutional websites, however, several broader trends are likely to appear. Labor visibility is expected to remain inconsistent, with frequently invoked terms such as “collaboration,” “support,” and “consultation” appearing in vague or polyvalent ways. The majority of websites may place more emphasis on platforms, infrastructure, or tools rather than on the workers themselves, which reflects the larger invisibility of labor that has been observed in DH study. I'm expecting that the rhetorical decisions may also be influenced by regional variations, such as the humanities-focused universities in the South and the more

technology-focused institutions in the West. Overall, I'm expecting the study is likely to show a substantial discrepancy between the scope of DH labor and how it is portrayed online, which would support claims made in the literature regarding rhetorical framing, invisibility, and the institutional identity work done by DH web spaces.

Future Research

Future study should focus on faculty-side perception studies. This could be done through examining how faculty members view library DH webpages and whether communication tactics affect their readiness to work together. Further, research that compares different institutional types like R1s, liberal arts colleges, or community colleges starting DH work could also show how rhetorical framing is influenced by institutional class. Additionally, longitudinal research will be especially helpful in tracking how DH message changes when programs develop, grow, or gain additional money. Finally, ethnographic research focused on matters of labor, such as shadowing DH librarians or staff in lab environments, may further uncover the day-to-day forms of invisible labor that web representation obscures. To find out how responsibility and competence are framed differently, other studies could focus on examining DH communication across campus units such as within DH centers, IT departments, and humanities departments. Finally, future studies may also want to examine how DH rhetoric adjusts to new types of automation and computational inquiry as AI-driven research tools continue to permeate and change many academic workflows.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Interview Protocol (Draft)

Introductory Questions

1. Can you describe your role in DH work at your institution?
2. How long have you been involved with DH initiatives?

Core Study Questions

3. How does your library communicate DH work externally (websites, LibGuides, documentation)?
4. What principles or goals guide your communication strategy?
5. Are there areas of DH labor that feel invisible or hard to convey publicly?
6. How do faculty or students typically respond to the library's DH messaging?
7. Do you believe your outward-facing materials accurately represent your DH work?

Closing Questions

8. Is there anything you wish your institution communicated differently about DH?
9. Anything else you want to add?

Appendix B: Coding Framework (Draft)

Primary Codes

- Labor Visibility

- Expertise/Authority Claims
- Collaboration Framing
- Infrastructure Emphasis
- Service Orientation
- Terminology (e.g., “digital scholarship,” “digital humanities”)
- Audience Targeting
- Institutional Identity Language

Secondary Codes

- Aspirational vs. operational tone
- Resource gaps
- Tool-centered vs. people-centered framing
- Regional references

Appendix C: Website Sampling Sheet (Draft)

Institution	URLS/ Web Assets Collected	Date Scraped	Notes
Stanford University	CESTA, Digital Scholarship pages, DH Lab pages	Jan 2025	Robust DH ecosystem; strong collaboration rhetoric

University of Washington – Seattle	DH Research Guide, DS initiative pages	Jan 2025	Interdisciplinary framing; consultation emphasis
University of Virginia	Scholars’ Lab website, Fellows program pages	Jan 2025	Established DH model; strong experimentation rhetoric
Emory University	ECDS pages, instructional support	Jan 2025	Pedagogy emphasis; co-research identity
University of Illinois–Chicago	Digital Scholarship pages, DH LibGuides	Jan 2025	Developing services; service-oriented rhetoric
Northwestern University	DH Lab, DS pages	Jan 2025	Mature infrastructure; collaboration/leadership language
University of Pittsburgh	Digital Scholarship Services, DH LibGuides	Jan 2025	Distributed DH presence; mixed clarity

Barnard College	Digital Scholarship & Pedagogy Lab	Jan 2025	Liberal arts framing; community/empowerment rhetoric
University of Nebraska–Lincoln	CDRH website, DH project portfolios	Jan 2025	Major DH center; long-term stewardship emphasis

Appendix D: Website Scraping Protocol (Draft)

This is a protocol for outlining the procedures for systematically collecting and archiving public-facing DH–related web materials from participating academic libraries.

1. Identification of Eligible Websites

- a. - Confirm institutional inclusion criteria (DH presence, librarian involvement, accessible materials).
- b. Identify all DH-related content:
 - i. DH centers or labs
 - ii. Library DS/DH service pages
 - iii. DH LibGuides
 - iv. Project portfolios
 - v. Workshops, tutorials, or consultation info
 - vi. Blog posts or announcements

2. Data Collection Procedures

- a. Capture all URLs relevant to DH work.
- b. Save webpages as:
 - i. PDF for static archival
 - ii. HTML for structure preservation
 - iii. Screenshots for layout/context
 - iv. Record the date and type of capture on the sampling sheet.

3. Metadata Documentation

- a. For each webpage, record:
 - i. URL
 - ii. Page title
 - iii. Type of content (service, project, instructional, news)
 - iv. Notes on DH terminology and rhetorical framing

4. Storage, Organization, and Versioning

- a. Store files in institution-specific folders.
- b. Maintain index spreadsheet with collected metadata.
- c. Version-control updates if pages change during study. (change use web.archive.org to cross reference)

5. Ethical Considerations

- a. Will use only publicly accessible content.
- b. Will not bypass authentication barriers.
- c. Respect institutional robots.txt directives.
- d. Acknowledge institutional authorship in reporting.

6. Quality Control

- a. Revisit pages with missing or broken elements.
- b. Re-scrape problematic content.
- c. Document all unusable or missing pages as study limitations.

Appendix E: Codebook for Rhetorical and Thematic Analysis

Code	Definition	Example Indicators
Collaborator	Positions librarians as co-researchers or equal partners.	“partner,” “co-develop,” “work alongside faculty”
Service Provider	Frames librarians as helpers or support staff.	“support services,” “consultation,” “help with tools”
Facilitator	Emphasizes enabling work rather than leading.	“connect researchers,” “guide process,” “provide workshops”

Leadership/Expertise	Claims institutional authority or specialized staff expertise.	“leading center,” “expert team,” “recognized for DH work”
Pedagogy Emphasis	Focus on teaching, curriculum, or student skill-building.	“instructional support,” “class projects,” “student-centered DH”
Tone: Institutional	Administrative, formal, policy-like language.	Mission statements, procedural language
Tone: Collegial	Friendly, collaborative tone	“work with us,” “we welcome collaboration”
Tone: Promotional	Marketing language highlighting innovation.	“cutting-edge,” “state-of-the-art,” “innovative approaches”
Visibility Claims	Statements highlighting prominence or recognition.	“nationally known,” “pioneering initiatives”